

Exploring Classics: A Dialogue on Literature and Mythology

English Lesson: Literature & Mythology Deep Dive

A cross-cultural dialogue bridging Russian classics, Greek epics, and modern AI tools.

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

Susan (Tutor)

Retired licensed teacher with 27 years in junior high; 7 years at Engoo. Loves news, soaps, and her 6 dogs.

Anatoly (Student)

Accountant based in Moscow. Enthusiast of AI tools, traveling, and creating structured presentations for learning.

"Achilles' heel is used as an idiomatic expression nowadays... talking about the weakness of a person."

THEMATIC ANALYSIS: THE ILIAD

1 **The Fatal Anger**

Discussion on Achilles' pride and the "Weapon of Mass Destruction" — his fatal wrath.

2 **Divine Intervention**

Apollo's plague as a response to Agamemnon's hubris and the petition of the priest Chryses.

3 **Motivations of War**

Debate: Was the 10-year Trojan war truly about Helen, or the immense wealth of Troy?

AUTHORS MENTIONED

#Homer

#Tolstoy

#EmileZola

#Fitzgerald

#Aristotle

Focus: Conversational English & Literary Analysis

Date: August 09, 2026

This document summarizes an online English language lesson between Susan, a veteran educator, and Anatoly, a Moscow-based accountant. The session transitioned from personal introductions to a collaborative analysis of classical literature, specifically focusing on Homer's *Iliad* through an AI-generated presentation.

Detailed Point Summary

Participant Profiles and Learning Objectives

The session began with introductions where Susan shared her background as a licensed teacher with 27 years of experience in junior high schools and seven years on the Engoo platform. Anatoly, based in Moscow, works as an accountant and has recently dedicated significant time to exploring artificial intelligence tools. His primary goals for the lesson were to practice free conversation and receive corrections on his English usage [00:47-02:38](#).

Lesson Participant Profiles

Susan (Teacher)

27+ Years Experience
Interests: News, Dogs, Literature

Anatoly (Student)

Accountant from Moscow
Interests: AI Tools, Travel, Reading

Literary Exchange and Artistic Interests

The conversation covered a wide array of literary works and authors. Susan highlighted her preference for novels by Emile Zola, Ernest Hemingway, and Sidney Sheldon, while Anatoly mentioned his interest in Jules Verne and Russian classics like Leo Tolstoy and Alexander Pushkin. They also briefly touched upon art history, mentioning Leonardo da Vinci and Michelangelo, and discussed F. Scott Fitzgerald's bibliography [04:28-05:4907:03-08:5210:38-12:16](#).

Thematic Analysis of Homer's Iliad

A significant portion of the lesson was dedicated to Anatoly's presentation on the *Iliad*. They discussed the "fatal anger" of Achilles and the origin of the "Achilles' heel" idiom as a metaphor for personal weakness. The dialogue also explored the complexities of the Trojan War, debating whether the conflict was truly about Helen of Troy or a strategic pursuit of Troy's wealth. Susan connected this to her experience teaching Greek and Roman mythology, while Anatoly emphasized the timeless relevance of these classical themes [14:47-17:5620:18-22:01](#).

Key Discussion: The Iliad

 **Achilles' Heel:** Discussion on the idiomatic expression for vulnerability.

 **Divine Intervention:** How gods like Apollo manipulated human actions.

 **War Motivations:** The theory that wealth, not just Helen, drove the Greeks to Troy.

 **Classical Relevance:** Why these stories remain relevant in modern culture.

Philosophical Reflections

The participants briefly detoured into political science and philosophy. Susan recalled her studies of Aristotle, Plato, and Socrates, specifically noting John Locke's philosophy regarding the inherent goodness of man. This served as a bridge between the mythological themes of the *Iliad* and broader humanistic concepts [13:27-14:27](#).

To-Do / Next Steps

- Anatoly to reread the story of the *Iliad* to prepare for deeper future discussions. [24:08](#)
- Susan to consider watching the movie *Helen of Troy* to compare cinematic interpretations with the original text. [24:34-24:47](#)
- Both participants to continue the discussion on classical presentations if they meet for a subsequent class. [24:08](#)

Conclusion

The lesson successfully combined language practice with high-level intellectual exchange. By utilizing AI-assisted tools to facilitate a discussion on classical mythology, the student was able to practice complex vocabulary and thematic analysis, while the teacher provided historical context and pedagogical insights.